🌿 CULTURAL CONSIDERATIONS · ALL YEAR LEVELS

Acknowledgement of Country & Cultural Considerations

Guidance for teaching water safety in a way that is culturally responsive, respectful of First Nations knowledge, and equitable for all students — for use across Year 7–8 and Year 9–10.

All year levels | Cross-curriculum priority | First Nations perspectives | Culturally responsive practice

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF COUNTRY

We acknowledge the **Traditional Custodians** of the lands and waters on which we teach and learn. We pay our respects to Elders past, present, and emerging. We recognise that **waterways — rivers, lakes, estuaries, coastlines, and seas — hold deep cultural, spiritual, and practical significance** for First Nations peoples across Australia. This significance predates European settlement by tens of thousands of years, and continues today.

In teaching water safety, we acknowledge that we are working within landscapes that are not simply natural features — they are Country. We teach on, near, and about waters that carry stories, protocols, and relationships that we must approach with care and respect.

🌊 Why Cultural Considerations Matter in Water Safety Education

🌿 First Nations Relationships with Water

For Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples, waterways are not simply recreational spaces or safety hazards — they are places of deep cultural, spiritual, and ecological significance. Rivers, billabongs, coastlines, and wetlands are embedded in Songlines, Dreamtime stories, and custodianship responsibilities that have been maintained for over 60,000 years.

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Water safety education that treats waterways purely as physical environments to be navigated or avoided may inadvertently fail to acknowledge this deeper relationship. Respectful teaching acknowledges that **Country — including water — is alive with meaning** and that First Nations peoples have sophisticated, place-based knowledge about water that predates Western safety frameworks.

When teaching about safe and unsafe waterways, be aware that for some students and families, particular waterways carry cultural significance that shapes how they engage with those places. This is not a barrier to safety — it is context that enriches safety education.

🌀 Cultural Protocols Around Water

Different Aboriginal communities across Australia have different protocols related to water. While these vary significantly between Country and community, some general principles that teachers should be aware of include:

- Some waterways are sacred and entry may be restricted for cultural reasons. This is a legitimate and important form of water management that deserves respect, not dismissal.
- Some communities have cultural protocols about discussing certain waterways, particularly those associated with significant ceremonies or Dreaming stories. If a student is reluctant to engage with content about a specific waterway, this may reflect cultural respect rather than disengagement.
- In many communities, water is associated with spiritual beings and presences. This should be acknowledged respectfully — not dismissed as superstition — as it is a legitimate cultural worldview.
- Fishing and gathering from waterways is a cultural practice with deep significance beyond recreation. Water safety in these contexts carries different meaning and different stakes for some community members.

Teachers do not need to be experts in the specific protocols of every community. The key is to **approach the subject with humility, curiosity, and a willingness to learn from students and families**.

⚠️ First Nations Over-Representation in Drowning Data

Australian drowning statistics show that Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples experience significantly higher drowning rates than non-Indigenous Australians. This is a **structural and historical inequity**, not a reflection on individual behaviour or communities. Contributing factors include:

- Historical exclusion from public swimming pools under segregation-era policies — creating generational skill gaps that persist today
- Geographic factors — higher rates of rural and remote living near unpatrolled waterways without lifeguard infrastructure
- Limited access to swimming lessons and aquatic education in remote communities
- Language barriers to mainstream water safety messaging
- Higher rates of occupational waterway exposure (fishing, hunting) without access to modern safety equipment

When teaching about drowning disproportionality in Year 9–10, **always frame First Nations over-representation as a structural inequity requiring structural solutions** — not as a cultural or behavioural deficit. This framing is both accurate and respectful.

⚠️ Cultural safety protocol — before you teach this unit

This unit teaches death by drowning, using real Victorian cases. In any class of twenty-five there is a reasonable chance that someone has lost a family member or community member to drowning, or has been present at one. The pastoral care note in Lesson 1 is a reminder; this is the protocol it was short of.

When	Do this	Why
Before the unit starts	Check with your wellbeing team and, where relevant, your Koorie Engagement Support Officer or Multicultural Education Aide, whether any student in the class has a known connection to a drowning or water-related death. Ask before you need to know, not after a disclosure.	You cannot make a judgement in the moment about content you have already shown.
Lesson 1, opening	Tell the whole class, plainly and once: this unit deals with real deaths; some of it may be close to home; anyone can step out at any point without explaining and without it counting against them. Name where they can go and who they can talk to.	An opt-out offered to the class costs a student nothing to use. An opt-out a student has to request privately is one most will not take.

When	Do this	Why
Before each case study	Give advance notice of what is coming — location, and that it involves a death — before the detail appears on a screen.	Being able to prepare, or leave, is the difference between difficult content and an ambush.
First Nations content	Do not use images, footage or audio of deceased persons. Where a resource may contain them, say so before it is shown. Follow local community protocols; where you are unsure, ask through your Koorie Engagement Support Officer rather than deciding yourself.	This is a cultural protocol, not a preference, and it is named in the department's own cultural responsiveness guidance. Breaching it causes real harm and is avoidable.
Any discussion of over-representation	Never invite a student to explain or speak for their community. If a student volunteers their own experience, receive it and move on — do not follow up with questions in front of the class.	Being made the class representative for a group's drowning statistics is an experience students remember, and not kindly.
Practical sessions	Check swimwear, changing and observation requirements with families before the first session, not at the pool. Offer a non-swimmer pathway that is a real alternative rather than a consolation. Treat a student's reluctance to enter water as information, not defiance.	Religious and cultural requirements around dress and mixed-sex settings are foreseeable. A student who cannot participate as arranged will often simply not come.
If a student discloses	Follow your school's wellbeing and child safety processes immediately. Do not promise confidentiality, do not probe for detail, and do not handle it alone.	Your obligations here are set by school and departmental policy, and they override anything in a teaching resource.

What this protocol is not. It is not your school's wellbeing policy, child safety policy or critical incident procedure, and it does not replace any of them. Where this page and your school's processes differ, follow your school. Where this unit meets a situation neither covers — a recent local drowning, a death in the school community — stop and take advice before teaching it. There are weeks when the right decision is to postpone the unit, and that decision is yours to make, not a resource's.

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🏫 Culturally Responsive Classroom Practice

📋 What to Do — and What to Avoid

Context	Recommended approach	Avoid
Discussing Victorian drowning statistics that show First Nations over-representation	**Frame as structural inequity. Acknowledge historical exclusion from swim facilities. Connect to community-level solutions.**	**Framing as individual or cultural failing. Implying that Indigenous communities "don't value" swimming or safety.**
Teaching about dangerous waterways (rivers, billabongs, remote beaches)	**Acknowledge that these are also sites of cultural significance. Teach safety without dismissing the value of the place.**	**Describing waterways only as hazards. Ignoring that some students' families have deep, legitimate relationships with these places.**
Discussing the BeachSafe app and lifeguard patrols	**Acknowledge that lifeguard infrastructure is not evenly distributed and that remote communities have fewer resources.**	**Implying that people who swim at unpatrolled locations are simply making bad choices.**
Opening a lesson near a significant waterway (e.g. Yarra River, Port Phillip Bay, Murray)	**Name the Traditional Custodians of that waterway. Acknowledge its cultural significance before discussing safety.**	**Treating the waterway purely as a physical environment with no cultural dimensions.**

Context	Recommended approach	Avoid
Engaging Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander students in the class	**Invite (not demand) sharing of community knowledge. Treat shared cultural knowledge with respect and as valuable.**	**Putting students on the spot as "representatives" of all First Nations peoples. Over-focusing on trauma or deficit narratives.**
CALD students and families from communities with limited swim access	**Frame limited swim access as a structural issue. Provide information about free and low-cost community programs.**	**Implying that families who haven't prioritised swimming lessons are being negligent.**

🌱 Integrating First Nations Knowledge — Classroom Protocols

🗣️ Invitation, not obligation

Invite First Nations students to share knowledge about their Country's waterways — but never require them to do so. Sharing cultural knowledge is a choice, not a curriculum responsibility.

📍 Localise the Acknowledgement

Name the specific Country and Custodians for your local waterways — not just a generic acknowledgement. AIATSIS mapping resources can help identify Traditional Custodians at aiatsis.gov.au/explore/map-indigenous-australia.

📚 Use verified resources

When incorporating First Nations water knowledge, use resources developed in collaboration with community — not third-party summaries. AIATSIS and local Land Councils are reliable starting points.

🔄 Reciprocal learning

Frame the unit as: "Western safety frameworks have important knowledge — so do First Nations custodianship traditions. We can learn from both." This positions Indigenous knowledge as complementary, not subordinate.

🏫 Connect with community

If your school is in or near a community with strong First Nations connections, consider inviting an Elder or community

✅ Curriculum alignment

This content addresses the cross-curriculum priority: Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Histories and Cultures. It

member to speak about their relationship with local waterways.

can be embedded in HPE without requiring a separate lesson.

🌏 CALD Communities — Culturally Responsive Practice

🤝 Approaching CALD Drowning Risk with Respect

Life Saving Victoria reports that 37% of Victorian drowning deaths since 2015–16 were people from multicultural backgrounds — and 46% among 15–24-year-olds specifically. Research summarised in LSV's Aquatic Injury Prevention Agenda 2026–27 found that 86% of surveyed international students misread the 'swim between the flags' symbol, taking it to mean a danger zone, a sports area or a private zone rather than the safest place to swim. That is a failure of signage design, not of the audience. This is a structural inequity — driven by historical limited swim access, language barriers to safety messaging, and occupational risk factors — not a cultural deficit.

- **Avoid deficit framing:** Never imply that CALD families "don't care about safety" or "choose not to swim." Limited swim access is structural, not attitudinal.
- **Multilingual resources:** The suite includes a multilingual parent information sheet (English, Simplified Chinese, Hindi, Burmese). Use it. Share it with families.
- **Mixed-gender facilities:** Be aware that some students and families may have cultural concerns about mixed-gender swimming environments. Acknowledge this respectfully and work with families where possible.
- **Religious and cultural dress:** Modest swimwear is legitimate and should be accommodated. Never frame cultural dress as a safety barrier in ways that are shaming.
- **Community programs:** Life Saving Victoria's multicultural safety team runs targeted swim programs for CALD communities. Families can be referred to lsv.com.au/community/multicultural-safety/

💭 Reflection Prompts for Teachers

Does my teaching about dangerous waterways acknowledge that these places also hold cultural significance for some students and their families?

When I discuss drowning statistics, do I explain structural causes — or does my framing inadvertently suggest individual or cultural fault?

Do I know the Traditional Custodians of the waterways most relevant to my students' lives — the local beach, river, or reservoir?

Are my resources accessible to EAL/D families? Have I shared the multilingual parent information sheet?

When a First Nations student shares knowledge about Country, do I treat it with the same respect I would give to a citation from a scientific source?

Do I have connections to local First Nations community members or organisations who could enrich this unit?

📚 Further Reading & Resources

- **AIATSIS Map of Indigenous Australia:** aiatsis.gov.au/explore/map-indigenous-australia — identify Traditional Custodians of local waterways
- **Reconciliation Australia:** reconciliation.org.au — resources for culturally responsive practice in schools
- **LSV Multicultural Safety:** lsv.com.au/community/multicultural-safety/ — community swim programs and CALD resources
- **RLSSA Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Drowning Report:** royallifesaving.com.au — national data on First Nations drowning rates with structural analysis
- **Victorian Curriculum — Cross-curriculum priorities:** victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au/cross-curriculum-priorities/aboriginal-and-torres-strait-islander-histories-and-cultures
- **Deadly Sista Girlz:** RLSSA program supporting Aboriginal girls' water safety — royallifesaving.com.au/programs

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